

Data Retention & Archival Policy

1. Purpose

This policy defines the standards governing the retention, archival, and secure disposal of enterprise data. Its purpose is to ensure compliance with legal and regulatory requirements, minimize data-related risk, optimize storage utilization, and maintain operational continuity across business units.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all organizational data assets including structured databases, unstructured documents, email records, backups, cloud repositories, system logs, and physical records. All employees, contractors, and third parties handling company data must comply with this policy.

3. Data Classification Categories

Enterprise data shall be classified into categories such as Customer Information, Financial Records, Vendor Contracts, Employee Records, Operational Logs, and Legal Documentation. Retention requirements differ based on regulatory obligations and business necessity.

4. Retention Period Standards

Retention schedules are determined by statutory mandates, contractual commitments, litigation exposure, and operational needs. Data shall not be retained longer than necessary unless legally required.

Examples of retention standards include:

- 1 Customer transaction records: 7 years from transaction closure.
- 2 Financial accounting records: 10 years per reporting regulations.
- 3 Vendor contracts: Contract duration plus 6 years.
- 4 HR employment records: Employment term plus 8 years.
- 5 Security logs: Minimum 24 months unless extended for investigation.

5. Archival Procedures

Data transitioning from active use to archival storage must be encrypted, access-controlled, and maintained in tamper-evident systems where applicable. Archived data must remain retrievable within defined service level thresholds.

6. Legal Hold & Exception Management

Upon notification of litigation, audit, or regulatory inquiry, relevant data shall be placed under legal hold. Deletion and modification workflows must be suspended until the hold is formally lifted.

7. Secure Deletion & Disposal

At the end of the retention lifecycle, data must be permanently destroyed using approved secure deletion techniques such as cryptographic erasure, certified media destruction, or compliant secure wiping standards.

8. Roles & Responsibilities

Data Owners define classification and retention rules. IT Operations implements archival and deletion mechanisms. Compliance monitors regulatory adherence. Internal Audit conducts periodic reviews of retention controls.

9. Monitoring & Policy Review

This policy shall be reviewed annually or upon significant regulatory change. Metrics including deletion accuracy, retrieval latency, and exception frequency shall be tracked to ensure effectiveness.